Mahipala I (988 - 1038)

Mahipala I was the most powerful ruler of the Pala dynasty. He is called the founder of the second Pala dynasty. The decline of Pratiharas gave the Palas an opportunity to take a leading role in North Indian affairs. But he could not extend his domain beyond Banaras because of the impressive campaigns of the Chola king from the South, Rajendra Chola. Mahipala restored the old glory of the Palas. He constructed and repaired a large number of religious buildings at Banaras, Sarnath and Nalanda.

The Pala dynasty declined soon after the death of Mahipala and gave way to the Sena dynasty.

The Chauhans

The Chauhans ruled between A.D. (CE) 956 and 1192 over the eastern parts of the present-day Rajasthan, establishing their capital at Sakambari. This Rajput dynasty was founded by Simharaji, who was popularly known as the founder of the city of Ajmer.

The Chauhans were the feudatories of the Pratiharas and staunchly stood by them to check the Arab invasions. The last of Chauhan kings, Prithiviraj Chauhan, was considered the greatest of all Chauhan rulers. He defeated Muhammad Ghori in the first battle of Tarain fought in 1191. However, he was defeated and killed in the second battle of Tarain in 1192.

Contribution of Rajputs to Art and Architecture

Art

Rajput courts were centres of culture where literature, music, dance, paintings, fine arts and sculpture flourished. A specific style of Rajput painting—often focusing on religious themes emerged at Rajput courts. Their style of painting is called 'Rajasthani'. The Rajasthani style of painting can be seen at Bikaner, Jodhpur, Mewar, Jaisalmer (all in Rajasthan).



Rajasthani Painting

Architecture

The Rajputs were great builders. Some of the important examples of the Rajput buildings are the strong fortresses of Chittorgarh. Ranathambhor and Kumbahlgarh



There is a long epic poem *Prithvirajraso,* composed by the bard Chand Bardai, a few centuries later. The story goes like this: The daughter of the King of Kanauj was to marry. A *swayamwara* (the bride choosing the bridegroom of her choice) was held to enable her to choose her husband. But she was in love with Prithiviraj and desired to marry him. Prithiviraj was the enemy of her father. In order to insult him, the King of Kanauj had not only denied him an invitation but had placed a statue of Prithiviraj as door keeper at the entrance to his court. To the shock of everyone assembled, the princess rejected the princes present and garlanded the statue of Prithiviraj, indicating her choice. Prithiviraj, who had been hiding in the vicinity, jumped in and rode away with the princess in a horse. Later both of them were married.

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